

DOES STAYING PUT PROTECT?

How Length of Residence Shapes the Neighborhood Cohesion-Alcohol Link Among U.S. Adults

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INTRODUCTION

Neighborhood social cohesion is widely viewed as protective for health, but whether tight community ties also shield adults from risky drinking is unclear. This study asks whether *how long* people have lived in their neighborhood changes the cohesion-alcohol relationship among working-age U.S. adults.

KEY FINDINGS

- Higher cohesion was linked to **greater** odds of both binge (OR = 1.11) and weekly heavy drinking (OR = 1.14), even after full adjustment.
- Compared with newer residents (<4 years), those living 4-10 or ≥10 years had **11-13% lower odds of binge drinking**.
- The cohesion-binge slope was **steepest among recent movers**: newcomers appear to be quickly drawn into local drinking occasions.
- Among long-term (≥10-year) residents, the cohesion-**heavy** drinking link **strengthened** (OR = 1.13), pointing to entrenched drinking norms in long-standing communities.
- Patterns held across sexes; men drank more overall, but cohesion slopes were parallel for men and women.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Cohesion is **not uniformly protective**: tight-knit ties can normalize and sustain risky drinking.
- **Newcomers** face the sharpest cohesion-driven rise in binge episodes during early settlement.
- **Long-term residents**, especially men, may carry habitual heavy drinking embedded in established social routines.
- Community-building should pair social connection with **alcohol-harm reduction**, including alcohol-free gatherings and norms messaging that distinguishes social bonding from drinking.

RESEARCH DESIGN

- Analyzed **78,398 adults aged 25-65** from the National Health Interview Survey (2013-2018).
- Measured perceived **neighborhood cohesion** (4-item index):
 - trust in neighbors
 - shared values
 - willingness to help
 - close-knit ties
- Categorized **length of residence**:
 - less than 4 years
 - 4-10 years
 - 10 years and over
- Modeled past-year **binge drinking** (≥5 drinks/occasion) and weekly **heavy drinking** (≥15 drinks/week men; ≥8 women).
- Applied survey-weighted logistic regression with sex-stratified cohesion-residency interactions.

MAIN THEMES

This study challenges the assumption that strong neighborhood cohesion always promotes healthier habits. Cohesion is *double-edged*: tight communities can both enhance social ties *and* normalize drinking, especially among newcomers and long-standing residents.

FOR MORE

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